

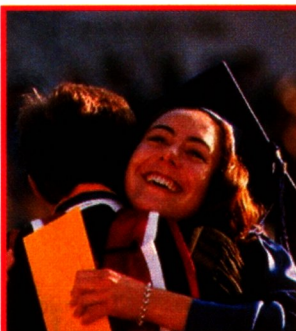
is through examinations such as the Common Admission Test (CAT) or Xavier Aptitude Test (XAT). A typical entrance paper constitutes questions that evaluate a candidate's quantitative (mathematics), verbal, logical and data interpretive abilities. Only those who score a high percentile in each section in the test are eligible for the next rounds of interview and group discussions. Many claim that it is a high dose of mathematics in the written exam that tilts it in favour of engineers. Saibal Chattopadhyay, dean (Programme Initiative) at IIM-Calcutta, agrees, "The quantitative section is quite pronounced in the tests which gives engineering students an upper edge." In such examinations, time is a deciding factor. One needs to crack 75 questions in 150 minutes. Obviously, those who come from a technical background are swifter with their number crunching skills.

Some may even argue that only one-third of the paper is devoted to mathematics, and the remaining sections deal with English and data

analysis. But these sections too are not as neutral as they sound. Admits Sourav Mukherji, associate professor, Organisational Behaviour, IIM-Bangalore, "Even the verbal section is more analytical than being language-oriented. This is done so that candidates from non-English backgrounds do not suffer." However, the step has further undermined the chances of applicants from humanities background, who may not have quantitative skills as their forte, but could be excellent in English.

Colleges that follow a different selection pattern invariably end up with a healthier ratio. Take for instance, Mudra Institute of Communications (MICA) which offers a post-graduate diploma in management (communications). Its classroom comprises a large number of students from humanities. "After we screen candidates through CAT, we conduct a separate admission test, the MICAT, that tests skills such as team building and creative thinking," explains Atul Tandan,

Many claim that it is the structure of the written test that gives engineering students an upper hand.



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